The very week that Musharraf launched his coup, 650 million Indians went peacefully to voting stations nationwide, reelecting Prime Minister Vajpayee's BJP-led coalition. Never before had the polar differences between India's robust democracy and Pakistan's inability to extricate itself from dependence on dictatorial military dominance been so clear. Vajpayee's Foreign Minister Jaswant Singh cautioned U.S. Deputy Secretary of State Strobe Talbott that Islamic forces of "destabilization and disintegration" were turning Pakistan into "a failed state."[5] Talbott feared, however, that as long as such "utter pessimism" about Pakistan dominated thinking in New Delhi, there could be little hope of India exercising a positive influence over Islamabad. Without democratic India's assistance and support, Pakistan would only slip more easily into the hands of Muslim terrorists. It had never been more urgently important for India and Pakistan to resolve their festering conflicts. The best estimates of global intelligence agencies indicated that Pakistan had plutonium enough to arm between 60 and 100 nuclear warheads. Yet no Westerners were certain as to where those warheads were stored, or whether they were secure from potentially falling into the hands of Al-Qaeda or Taliban terrorists, who were active throughout most of Pakistan's volatile frontier.

Four decades of a "mutually assured destruction" (MAD) Cold War nuclear standoff between the United States and the Soviet Union had served to dispel most fears of nuclear war, which had come to be regarded as highly "unlikely." Those superpowers, however, were more remote from each other than India and Pakistan, and they had developed many more nuclear safeguards and effective early-warning systems than have as yet been introduced or mutually accepted in South Asia. Several leading Indian and Pakistani general officers, moreover, have at times argued in favor of "preventive war" against their closest neighbor, even after having crossed the nuclear threshold. In 1986, India's boldest chief of army staff, General Krishnaswamy Sundarji, launched a provocative year-long military "exercise"—"Brasstacks"—together with a land, sea, and air military "operation"—"Trident"—that engaged so many Indian forces so close to Pakistan's mid-border that the Pakistani army went on red alert.[6] Many students of Brasstacks believed Sundarji's "exercise" was actually designed to provoke a Pakistani attack, which could then be answered by a "decapitating" Indian nuclear strike against Pakistan. Sundarji revealed his frustrations in *Blind Men of Hindoostan*, his "fictionalised narrative" about an Indo-Pakistani nuclear war, by which he hoped to persuade the government of India "to institutionalise